

Sandstone

△ **Head of a reclining** Buddha statue carved in sandstone

Sandstone is found throughout the world and is one of the most common varieties of sedimentary rock. The tiny, sand-sized grains of mineral, rock, or organic material that make up its composition are reduced in size by weathering, and then compacted together over long periods of time. Mineral grains in sandstones are typically quartz or feldspar: these grains crystallize around the sand grains, cementing them together. Sandstone can be any colour, but is usually brown, yellow, red, grey, pink, or white; it has been used in carvings and architecture for centuries.

Specification

Rock type Continental, detrital, sedimentary | **Fossils**

Vertebrates, invertebrates, plants | **Major minerals**

Quartz, feldspar | **Minor minerals** Silica, calcium carbonate

Colours Cream to red | **Texture** Fine- to medium-grained,

angular to rounded | **Locations** Worldwide



Grainy surface | **Rough** | The rough, textured surface of this piece of rust-red sandstone is coated with tiny individual sand grains.



Sandstone boulder | **Rough** | This sandstone boulder could be split along its horizontal bedding planes to produce fine carving material.



Layered sandstone | **Rough** | Sandstone with different-coloured layers can be sawn across the bedding to reveal sand "pictures", as seen in this specimen.



Indian statue | **Carved** | This intricately detailed, red sandstone carving from 1st–2nd-century CE India has been coated with gesso before being painted.

Lotus carving | **Carved** | Sandstone can vary in hardness and some material can be difficult to carve, but when fine-grained, as here, it can be sculpted with great detail.

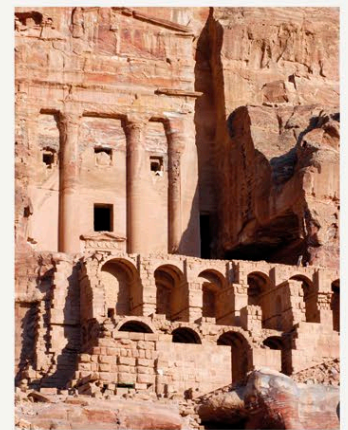
Detailed
flower buds



Petra

The Rose City

Petra is a famous archaeological site carved into pink sandstone cliffs in the southwest of Jordan, nicknamed the "Rose City" after the rich rose colour of the sandstone. Its intricately carved tombs and temples date back to 300 BCE, when Petra was capital of the Nabatean kingdom. The most famous temple is Al Khazneh, or "the Treasury", a building with an ornate façade, which is accessed via a narrow gorge more than 1km (½ mile) long and flanked on either side by 80m- (250ft-) high cliffs.



Rose-coloured columns The façade of this tomb, with its ornate columns, is carved into sandstone.